

CFO SIGHT RECORD

X unusual

3-4 1st
1-6 2nd
7-0 3rd

A

2000-27

SPECIES: RED-SHOULDERED HAWK

Buteo lineatus

rec'd 1/20/02

Date: 3/12/2000 Sunday (same day as Quesenberry sighting, although his record shows 3/11)

Number seen: (1) eastern juvenile sex- ?

Location: Cherry Creek S.P., Arapahoe County, Greenwood Village

Observation: 15 minutes - 0845-0900 MST. I observed alone for 9-10 minutes before joining group, because we were driving own cars and I stopped before the others on spotting the buteo.

Other observers: Dave Quesenberry, Ric Olson, DFO group.

Light: overcast; 42 degrees, calm; good frontal, side, and back views, looking to east, southeast and north.

Equip: Swarovski 8 x 56 bino, Kowa 2060 zoom scope

Distance: 50-120 yds. and beyond.

No photo.

Habitat: mature cottonwoods at north and south edges of a small wetland with waterfowl scattered throughout. Open grassland nearby, bordered on north by extensive deciduous woods and large reservoir.

Behavior: Originally seen perched 2/3 way up in a 50' tall mature cottonwood near park road. Flew to second cottonwood to the south, perched, then flew to the north woods. Flight direct with glides on classic bowed wings when flying between cottonwoods. Flight rapid with only a few glides on last flight, to north. Upright posture when perched. Stretched wing away from body lx while perched, showing underwing well. Actively looking about, some preening.

Description: medium-sized, slender buteo with long, narrow-banded tail (but not as narrow as in RTHA), shorter wings and a unique checkered pattern on secondaries. I quickly recognized this hawk as being very much like the one I had studied at length at Riverside Cemetery in north Denver 2 months earlier (1/3/2000). Hawk appeared somewhat smaller than Red-tailed Hawk (RTHA).

HEAD: distinctive; pale with extensive fine brown streaks on crown through nape, fine dark streaks radiating across pale auriculars and supercilium. Heavy, dark lateral throat stripe (malar) bordering white chin and throat. Buteo shaped bill was blackish with paler cere, but not particularly menacing in size. Face showed black eyeline, but iris color not recorded in notes.

UPPERPARTS: Medium brown mantle, scapulars and wing coverts with white mottling and spots. When perched, unique pattern of broken dark and light brown bars on secondaries and greater secondary coverts like rows of evenly-spaced spots and squares (checkered effect). Scapulars showed less white than on RTHA.

Primaries black with whitish, rather than expected buff colored, narrow panel at base of long primary "fingers" of P 10 to P 6 or P 5, creating a crescent on wing-tip clearly visible in flight from above and on stretched wing from below. No rufous noticed on wing coverts, although one DFO birder thought he caught a glimpse on red once.

Long, dark brown tail had multiple, evenly spaced pale bands with narrow white terminal tail band. The dark subterminal band appeared somewhat wider than other dark sections, but not as wide as in Broad-winged Hawk (BWAH). No dramatic difference was obvious in width of pale vs. dark sections in tail. Wing tips fell far short of tip of tail, but wings were not as short as those of accipiters.

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Red-shouldered Hawk (3/12/2000) cont.

UNDERPARTS: White/cream with heavy, broad, tightly-packed dark brown streaks from lower throat through lower belly, becoming more dense on belly. Undertail coverts and undertail off-white. Wing linings pale with no striking accent color or pattern. Black primary tips and white crescent panel visible from below when wing was stretched. Long legs, color not recorded.

No vocalization.

Similar species: Juv. RTHA - larger, more robust size, less tail projection beyond primaries; does not glide on bowed wings. Juv. RTHA has more extensive pale squarish panel on outer half of wing plus dark patagial marks on underwing. Shows more white on scapulars; breast of light morph, most closely resembling RSHA juvenile, is unstreaked. Tail bands narrower than on young RSHA.

Juv. Broad-winged Hawk - very similar. Slightly smaller in size, lacks pale primary crescent and patagial marks on underwing. BWA has wider subterminal tail band than buteo I saw. Secondaries on perched BWA are solid brown, lacking the light brown barring that creates the checkered pattern; legs are shorter.

Juv. accipiters (all): Tail very long, much shorter wings than RSHA. Pale primary crescent and heavy, dark lateral throat stripe are absent; pale tail bands noticeably wider than dark bands.

Previous experience: have seen RSHA 4 x in Colorado, but more often in Tx. and Calif. in past 6 yrs. BWA - a dozen x in CO., other sightings in Texas over 3 yrs. from 1993 - 1998. All accipiters and RTHA many times.

Books: Nat. Geo. and Hawks (Peterson and Wheeler) reviewed during sighting and immediately after buteo flew. Coincidentally, I had just spent the evening before studying Juv. RSHA in Hawks in Flight, (Dunn et.al.) in anticipation of a future sighting!

This report was written from notes made during and 1 hour after observation.

Date of rough draft 3/14/2000.

Typed and submitted to CBRC 1/22/2002.

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Karleen Schofield